

Banks: Measuring AI Maturity in Banking: Insights from the Evident AI Index CEO — Key Takeaways

We hosted a webcast with Alexandra Mousavizadeh, CEO and co-founder of the Evident AI Index, a global framework that measures AI maturity across financial services institutions. The discussion highlighted several key themes:

US still ahead: The Evident AI Index continues to be led by US banks, reflecting an earlier start to AI investment, stronger access to talent and deeper technology ecosystems. Evident highlighted hiring, execution and investment intensity as increasingly important differentiators between leaders and laggards.

Talent drives outcomes: Talent remains the largest component of the Index (45%) and was identified as the key enabler of AI adoption. Evident views Europe's shallower AI talent pool as one of the principal reasons for the gap versus the US, with success increasingly dependent on banks' ability to build, integrate and scale AI capabilities across the organisation.

Build vs Buy: US banks have largely pursued a build strategy, while European banks have been more inclined to partner with third-party providers. Evident noted that partnerships can create significant value, but the divergence reflects different starting positions, talent availability and organisational cultures.

Regulation: The approach adopted by European Banks (and European corporates more generally) with regards to 'responsible AI' is more cautious than peers in the US, and this likely reflects the anticipated regulatory framework which is yet to fully form, i.e. European companies at the margin may be holding back in anticipation of future regulation.

Leadership matters: Beyond talent, management commitment was highlighted as a critical determinant of success. Evident argued that effective AI adoption requires both strong CEO sponsorship and bottom-up execution, with leading institutions increasingly embedding AI expertise within business lines rather than relying solely on centralised innovation teams.

Jobs may grow: Contrary to widespread concerns that AI will drive material job losses across banking, Evident suggested that current trends point in the opposite direction at leading institutions. Growth in AI capabilities has been accompanied by continued investment in talent and front-line capacity (headcount savings are reinvested), with banks that are successfully deploying AI often adding resources to support growth and gain market share rather than shrinking headcount. Looking ahead, Evident suggested the greater risk may lie with institutions that fail to keep

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pace with adoption.

ROI still early: AI is beginning to move beyond experimentation, but meaningful financial benefits remain at an early stage. Private benchmarks indicate that c.85% of current use cases are focused on internal processes and efficiency initiatives, suggesting that the industry's AI opportunity is still in an early stage despite growing disclosure and adoption across leading banks.

Our view on the AI opportunity in European Banks: (see *'AI: Quantifying tailwinds, assessing headwinds', published February 2026*) AI has scope to drive a meaningful uplift in profitability, with our analysis of 32 use cases suggesting c.240bp of ROE improvement, driven primarily by cost efficiencies rather than revenue growth. The biggest beneficiaries are likely to be capital-light, cost-intensive banks where automation, enhanced credit analysis and greater cross-selling can materially improve returns, although benefits will vary significantly across business models. While adoption is already widespread, the key uncertainties remain the upfront investment required, evolving vendor pricing models and increasing regulatory scrutiny around AI governance and data use.

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